

Security: Outsource it?

How does an organisation handle its security? We ask two experts with contrasting views

“It’s not healthy to be entirely dependant on consultants”

Shashi Bhusan

IT representative, Students Council, IIM Calcutta

Indian Institute of Management, Calcutta, has 500 students on campus. Like any other organisation, we have some critical data that needs protection, such as e-mails exchanged between the professors and the students, CAT results, Web casts, message boards, etc. Add to this, the servers and Internet gateways that need to be filtered for junk mails. The placement season is a critical time when students’ profiles, resumes and company-related information become vulnerable to misuse.

The list of to-do things for IT security may seem large and one might ideally want a third-party to take care of security issues. But we have realised that it isn’t healthy to outsource security completely, or to be entirely dependant on consultants. We have a LAN Squad that consists of 12 members drawn from both years of management. The Squad is headed by an IT representative elected by the students. Every member of the squad is in charge of one server, apart from the proxy servers.

We have Norton Firewall for Internet security and the proxy servers are running on Linux, which has IPTables. Our gateways also have an Access Control List (ACL) that restricts the illegal access to our proxy server. Swatch and Trip is used for intrusion detection.

Managing the security is a little hectic for the students, especially during placement season. But it’s a hands-on experience; from the design to the implementation of a security system—something you usually don’t get once you start working for organisations.

“Outsourced security gives us peace of mind”

Atul Bansal

IT Head, BLA Industries Ltd.

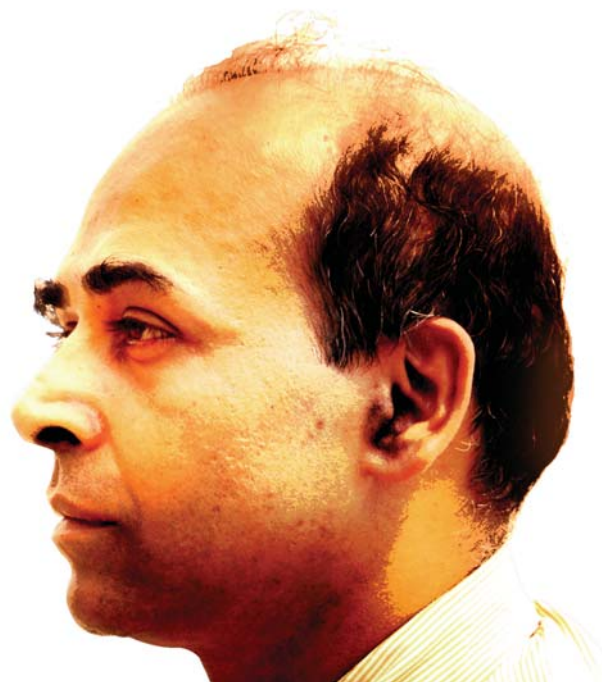
We are a 70-year-old company, manufacturing metallurgical coke. The link between factory, the coal mine, and the corporate office used to be a closed LAN/WAN line. As our usage of the Internet increased, we realised the need for greater security. Threats keep changing in names and forms. Prevalence of hacking, need for constant security updates, and increase in the number of users prompted us to secure our networks more fiercely than before.

However, we were just three people managing the IT needs of the company. We decided that it would be prudent for a third party to handle the security of the company. After internal discussions on the kind of security needed, we approached Trident Infotech Securities to manage our network security.

Trident has dedicated personnel for every aspect of security—anti-virus, firewalls, and storage. We had earlier met the company in a few seminars for security, had further meetings on what the company offered, and finally opted for their services. During the few months during which we had firewalls installed, we haven’t faced even a single virus threat.

An unprotected network is far more expensive than investing in its security. Having outsourced security, we have some peace of mind in terms of security updates, patches and improved versions.

— As told to Aparna Krishnakumar



photograph Mary Xavier